

## M6T1: Active Listening Skills — 10 min

**Video File** M6T1-Listening.mp4 (listening loop diagram) · **Resources** Listening Exercises.pdf (the loop, a practice session script, prompts, reflection) · **Xp** 90 total · Practice 1 Session 40 · Reflect 30 · Share 20

Target runtime 10 min · 1,129 spoken words · ≈ 7.5 min at 150 wpm · ≈ 8.4 min at a warm 135 wpm

0:00–0:30 **HOOK**

*[VISUAL: Cynthia on camera.]*

Most of us think we're listening when what we're actually doing is waiting. Waiting for the pause, so we can say the thing we've been holding since the second sentence. On the fertility journey, where both people are carrying so much, that kind of listening leaves everyone feeling unheard in the same room. Today I want to teach you the other kind. It's a skill, it's learnable in an afternoon, and I've watched it change households.

0:30–3:30 **THE SKILLS**

*[VISUAL: Listening loop diagram: Speak → Reflect → Check → Go deeper → Speak.]*

Active listening comes from the psychologist Carl Rogers, and it has three moves. First, attention: face the person, put the phone down, and let your eyes rest on theirs for most of the time they're speaking. Second, paraphrasing: when they

pause, say back what you heard, in your own words, without adding anything. "So what I'm hearing is that the appointment left you feeling like a number." Third, checking: "Did I get that right?" And then they correct you, or they say yes, and either way they go deeper, because they've just learned it's safe to.

*[VISUAL: Slide: "Active listening improves how understood people feel (International Journal of Listening)."]*

The research is clear on what this does. Harry Weger and colleagues, in the International Journal of Listening, compared active listening with simple acknowledgment and with advice-giving, and found that people who were listened to actively felt more understood and more satisfied with the conversation than people who received advice. Read that again: more satisfied than when they got advice. And Harry Reis's work on what he calls perceived partner responsiveness, the sense that your partner understands, values, and cares for you, has shown across many studies that it's one of the strongest predictors of relationship quality, intimacy, and even physical health. Responsiveness is built one paraphrase at a time.

*[VISUAL: Slide: "The three enemies of listening: fixing · defending · matching."]*

Three things kill listening. Fixing: they say "I'm scared," you say "Have you tried the breathing?" Defending: they say "I felt alone at the clinic," you say "I had a meeting, what was I supposed to do?" And matching: they say "I'm exhausted," you say "You think you're exhausted?" All three are natural. All three end the conversation. The loop replaces each of them with a reflection, and the reflection is the whole skill.

Let me be honest about why this is hard, especially on this journey. When the person you love is scared, your own fear rises to meet it, and fixing is what fear does with its hands. Reflecting instead of fixing means sitting in their fear for a minute without solving it, which feels like doing nothing. It isn't nothing. It's the thing. And there's a second reason it's hard for many men in particular: they've been taught that love is solving problems. Listening is a different kind of solving. It solves the loneliness, which is the problem underneath the problem.

3:30–8:30 DEMO: ROLE-PLAY

[VISUAL: Slide: "Fertility application: sharing fears and dreams."]

Let me show you the difference with a scenario that comes up constantly. One partner has just come back from a scan and is upset. I'll play both parts; the second voice is the partner.

*[DEMO: Cynthia turns slightly for each role, or a partner reads off camera. First: the usual way.]*

Here's the usual version. "The scan was awful. She barely looked at me and then said the follicle count was lower than they'd hoped." "Okay, but she said last time that numbers fluctuate. You always jump to the worst case." "I'm not jumping. I'm telling you what she said." "And I'm telling you not to panic. Did you ask about the supplement thing?" And now they're arguing about whether she's panicking, and the follicle count never got felt.

*[DEMO: Now the active-listening version. Slower.]*

Here's the loop. "The scan was awful. She barely looked at me and then said the follicle count was lower than they'd hoped." Attention: put the phone down, turn the body. Reflect: "So she was cold with you, and the count was lower than you'd hoped, and you're carrying both of those right now." Check: "Is that it?" "Yes. And I'm scared this means it isn't going to work." Reflect again: "You're scared this is the beginning of it not working." "Yes." Pause. And then the

question that opens the door: "What do you need from me right now, listening or ideas?"

*[VISUAL: Slide: "Listening or ideas?"]*

That question is the single most useful sentence in this module. "Listening or ideas?" It lets the person choose, and nine times out of ten, in the first ten minutes, they'll choose listening. The ideas can come later, and they'll land, because the person will already feel understood.

Notice what the listener didn't do. Didn't correct the panic. Didn't relitigate the meeting. Didn't bring up the supplement. All of that can happen tomorrow. Tonight, the job was to make one person feel less alone, and it took four sentences.

*[DEMO: A second short scenario, the dream version.]*

The loop works just as well for dreams, and that's the part couples skip. "I've been imagining what it'll be like to tell my mum." Reflect: "You've been picturing the moment you tell her." "Yeah. She'd cry. I'd cry." "You'd both cry." Pause. "What else have you been picturing?" That's it. Sharing a dream out loud, and having it reflected back rather than

managed, is one of the most bonding things two people can do, and it costs nothing.

One more skill for the loop: the follow-up question. After you've reflected and checked, ask one open question that goes deeper rather than sideways. "What was the hardest moment?" "What are you most afraid it means?" "What would help?" Not "why" questions, which put people on trial, and not "did you" questions, which lead somewhere you've already decided. Open, curious, one at a time. Then reflect again. Two rounds of the loop is usually enough for the person to feel fully heard; three is generous. It takes six or seven minutes, and it's the best six minutes of most days.

---

8:30–9:30 PRACTICE AND HEART-LED CLOSE

*[VISUAL: Slide: Listening Exercises preview: "10-minute practice session: 4 minutes each, 1 minute to swap, reflection."]*

Here's your practice. The Listening Exercises PDF has a ten-minute session: one person speaks for four minutes on a prompt, "something about this journey I haven't said," "a fear," "a dream," while the other only reflects and checks. Then swap. Then a two-minute reflection each on how it felt to be listened to without being fixed. Do it once this week. It

will feel artificial the first time. It also works the first time. If you're solo, do the practice with a friend, or by phone; being listened to is the same medicine wherever it comes from.

Listening has repaired more distance between partners than any advice I've ever given, and I've come to think of it as the closest thing to magic in this work. It's for your future family, too: the way you listen to each other now is the way you'll listen to a child.

#### 9:30–10:00 ACTION HANDOFF

*[VISUAL: End card: "Listening Exercises PDF → Practice 1 session (40 XP) → Reflect (30 XP) → Share in the forum (20 XP)."]*

Download the Listening Exercises, do one ten-minute session for forty XP, write your reflection for thirty, and share one thing you learned about listening in the forum for twenty. Next, Training Two: what to do when the conversation turns into a fight.

#### ACTION CALLOUT

**RESOURCE** Listening Exercises.pdf (the loop, three enemies, "listening or ideas?", 10-minute session script, prompts, reflection page, solo version). **ACTION 1:** Practice one 10-minute listening session (40 XP). **ACTION 2:** Write your reflection (30 XP). **ACTION 3:** Share one insight in the forum (20 XP). **NEXT STEP:** Training 2 · Conflict Resolution for Couples.